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Before you buy any AI tool

Ten questions for day 90

A demo shows what a tool can do once. These questions find out what it does on an ordinary Tuesday, three months in.



These days I spend most of my time on one gap: between a tool that works in a demo and one people still rely on months later. A demo shows a tool on its best day. Whether it deserves to stay is decided on the ordinary ones.

The questions I care about now are about day 90. By then the excitement has worn off, the person who pushed for the tool is busy with something else, and the work is your real work, messy cases included. Either the tool has quietly become part of how things get done, or it sits in a tab nobody opens.

These are the ten questions I'd ask before buying any AI tool, from anyone. I'd want them asked of anything I build, too. None of them needs a technical background. Numbers in the sample answers and the example are illustrations, not benchmarks.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Keep pages 2 and 3 open in the demo, or print them.
2. Ask each question and tick one box: answered, or still open.
3. Read your ticks with the decision guide on page 4. Questions marked "resolve first" must be answered before any pilot.

THE TEN, AT A GLANCE

1. What will my team stop doing?
2. Will you test it on our own cases, including the hard ones, before we commit?
3. What counts as a good result, and who decides?
4. Where does a person check the work, and how long does that take?
5. What can it do without a person, and what happens when a step goes wrong? · resolve first
6. What happens to our data? · resolve first
7. What will it cost in total for the first year, not only the subscription?
8. Which number will we look at on day 30, 60 and 90?
9. Who has used it for 90 days, and who stopped?
10. When do we decide whether to keep it, and how do we leave? · resolve first

1 What will my team stop doing?

☐ answered ☐ open

The real competitor is what you do today: the spreadsheet, the WhatsApp thread, the extra hour. If the gain on that one step is small, people drift back to the old way.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

"It replaces one step you do today. On your own work it took 40 minutes before and 4 after."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"It does everything." A feature tour, a "20% productivity boost", and no step you will actually stop doing.

2 Will you test it on our own cases, including the hard ones, before we commit?

☐ answered ☐ open

A demo shows what a tool can do once. Your own cases show what it does on an ordinary Tuesday.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

"Send us 20 real cases, a few hard ones included, as samples you're authorised to share, with personal and confidential details removed, through a route we agree. We'll run them while you watch."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"It tops the benchmarks." Only their sample data, a test you can't watch, or "just email us your files".

3 What counts as a good result, and who decides?

☐ answered ☐ open

If nobody writes down "good" before the start, day 90 becomes an argument about feelings.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A short written rule you agree before the trial: what a good output looks like, two or three examples of good and bad, and the person on your side who judges it.

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"You'll know it when you see it." Or "98% accurate", with no answer to "98% of what?"

4 Where does a person check the work, and how long does that take?

☐ answered ☐ open

The tools that last let the machine flag and the person who carries the consequence decide.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

"It drafts and flags the ones it's unsure about. Your person approves. A check takes about a minute."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"No human needed." Or a check that takes as long as doing the work yourself.

5 What can it do without a person, and what happens when a step goes wrong?

☐ answered ☐ open

RESOLVE BEFORE ANY PILOT

Small error rates add up. As an illustration: if ten steps must all succeed and each is right 95% of the time, the whole job is right only about 60% of the time. Test the complete workflow, not each step on its own.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

"It reads and drafts. Sending, deleting, paying or changing a record waits for your approval, and you can see and undo every step."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"Fully autonomous, end to end." Wide access to your systems, no log of what it did, and no way to undo it.

6 What happens to our data?

☐ answered ☐ open

RESOLVE BEFORE ANY PILOT

You should know where your files go before you send the first one.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Plain written answers: who can access it, how long it's kept, whether it's used to train any model, how you delete it, and how you export it in a format you can open.

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"It's all secure", with no detail. Training use "only to improve the service". Deletion or export "on request".

7 What will it cost in total for the first year, not only the subscription?

☐ answered ☐ open

The price on the page is rarely the whole cost. Your team's time is part of it.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A written estimate, line by line: subscription, usage charges at your volume, setup, connecting it to your systems, your team's review time, upkeep, and what leaving would cost.

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"It's just the monthly fee." Usage "pay as you go" with no estimate for your volume, or setup and exit costs left vague.

8 Which number will we look at on day 30, 60 and 90?

☐ answered ☐ open

Logins and sign-ups can climb while nothing changes. Pick a number tied to the work and read it week by week.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

One number you can check yourself: "the share of drafts your team used with small edits, by week. We expect it to climb."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

Totals that only go up: messages processed, users invited, hours "saved" by their own calculator.

9 Who has used it for 90 days, and who stopped?

☐ answered ☐ open

Ask about the last time, not the usual one. A young vendor may have nobody at day 90 yet: a gap in the evidence, not a verdict.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Two customers you can call on your own, and the story of the last one who stopped. Or, from a newer vendor: "Nobody has reached day 90 yet. Let's agree a short, bounded evaluation."

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

Logos, announcements and "they loved it", with nobody you can call and no story about anyone who stopped.

10 When do we decide whether to keep it, and how do we leave?

☐ answered ☐ open

RESOLVE BEFORE ANY PILOT

Book the decision before you start, while nobody has anything to defend.

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A review date and a number agreed now ("day 45: if fewer than 7 in 10 drafts are usable, we stop"), exit terms in writing, and your data back in a format you can open. A paid pilot or an annual contract can be fine once the exit is written down.

A RED FLAG SOUNDS LIKE

"Let's see how it goes." A long commitment before any result with no break point, or exit costs nobody will write down.

FICTIONAL, TO SHOW THE QUESTIONS AT WORK

A worked example

A seven-person trading company in Sharjah is offered a tool that reads supplier invoices from email and drafts the entries in its accounting software. The company, the people and every number below are made up, to show the questions at work.

What stops (1)	The first answer was “it runs your whole finance inbox”. The finance lead pushed for one step: keying in about 300 invoices a month at roughly four minutes each, so 20 hours a month.
Their own cases (2)	With the owner’s sign-off, she sent 40 invoices, bank details blacked out, through a folder both sides agreed. The tool got 30 of 32 clean PDFs right and 2 of 8 scans.
Resolved first (5, 6, 10)	In writing: it drafts and never posts; files are kept 30 days and never used for training; deletion is confirmed by email; export is a spreadsheet; there’s a break point at day 45.
Total cost (7)	Subscription, a per-invoice charge, a half-day setup, and about 2 hours a month of her review time, which she counted as part of the cost.
Pilot tests (8, 9)	Still open: the scans, and no customer at day 90 yet. Both became tests with an owner, reviewed on day 45: stop if fewer than 7 in 10 clean drafts are used without edits.
Day 45	9 in 10 clean drafts were used as they were, and that step went from about 16 hours a month to about 2. Scans stayed with a person. They kept it for clean invoices and booked the next review for day 90.

WHAT TO DO WITH YOUR ANSWERS

Practical guidance from experience, not a validated scoring system.

Resolve first.

An open answer on what it can do without a person (5), your data (6) or exit terms (10) stops the process. Don’t start a pilot until it’s answered in writing.

Test the rest.

Every other open answer becomes a written pilot test: what you’ll check, who owns it, and the date you’ll review it.

Then start small.

A bounded pilot, the review date booked, and the stop number agreed before day one.

WHERE THESE COME FROM

The questions come from my own work and from three books I’ve read. Page references correspond to the editions consulted and may differ in other editions.

Chip Huyen, *AI Engineering*. Ch. 4 on defining “good” before you build and making your own test sets (pp. 317, 396–398, 402–407); ch. 1 and ch. 6 on raising autonomy one step at a time and errors compounding across steps (pp. 82–83, 539–551). Questions 2–5.

Peter Thiel, *Zero to One*. Ch. 5 on the 10x bar for a better tool (p. 38); ch. 12 on software that flags and people who decide (pp. 106–113). Questions 1 and 4.

Eric Ries, *The Lean Startup*. Ch. 3 on validated learning (pp. 37–46); ch. 7 on actionable versus vanity metrics (pp. 104–109); ch. 8 on letters of intent that stalled when asked to pay, and on booking the pivot-or-persevere decision in advance (pp. 124–130). Questions 8–10.

No vendor asked for this or reviewed it. Copy it, share it, change it.

If you use this, I’d be interested to hear which question changed your decision.